Learn French for Beginners

La Lettre de Lyon

A story in 20 episodes · A2–B1



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The Letter from Lyon

A 20-episode story set in Lyon: Maya finds three love letters from 1962 and goes looking for the man who wrote them. Maya, a graphic designer from London, moves into her late grandmother's flat on the Croix-Rousse hill in Lyon. Behind a loose kitchen tile she finds three love letters from 1962, signed only "J.", and a sealed envelope in her grandmother's writing. With Théo, the bookseller downstairs, she sets out to find J.

How to read

Each line gives the speaker and the French, then the English in italics. The respellings (English-style pronunciation, not IPA) are only in the word list at the end of each episode; ‿ marks a liaison there (*vous avez* = voo‿zah-vay). The questions for every episode and the answer key are at the end.

Spelling	Sounds like
zh	the "s" in *measure* (French **j** / soft **g**)
uh	the "a" in *about*
ew	French **u**: say "ee" with your lips rounded like "oo"
N (capital)	nasal vowel: hum the vowel through your nose, don't say the "n"
ahN	nasal *an* / *en* (as in *France*)
ohN	nasal *on* (as in *bon*)
aN	nasal *in* / *ain* / *ien* (as in *vin*)
uhN	nasal *un* (as in *un*)
r	French throaty "r", made at the back of the throat
‿	liaison: the silent final consonant is pronounced at the start of the next word (*vous‿avez* = voo zah-vay)

The people

Maya, new neighbour (episodes 1, 2, 3, 4, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 13, 14, 15, 16, 18, 20)
Théo, bookseller (episodes 1, 2, 3, 5, 7, 10, 12, 14, 15, 17, 19, 20)
M. Rossi, neighbour (episode 4)
Mme Berthier, neighbour (episodes 5, 17)
M. Faure, archivist (episode 6)
M. Brun, market seller (episode 8)
M. Perrin, retired typesetter (episode 9)
M. Dumas, winegrower (episode 11)
Sabine, receptionist (episode 12)
Yanis, receptionist (episode 13)
Jacques, J. (episodes 16, 18)
Odile, Jacques's daughter (episode 19)

Contents

Act 1 · L'arrivée (Arrival) · A2

Episode 1 · L'emménagement (Moving in)
Episode 2 · Les lettres de J. (The letters from J.)
Episode 3 · Une adresse disparue (An address that's gone)
Episode 4 · Le voisin de la cour (The neighbour in the courtyard)
Episode 5 · Une porte qui se ferme (A door that closes)

Act 2 · L'enquête (The search) · A2

Episode 6 · Aux archives (In the archives)
Episode 7 · La photo (The photo)
Episode 8 · Le marchand se souvient (The market seller remembers)
Episode 9 · Le mauvais Jacques (The wrong Jacques)
Episode 10 · Un après-midi de pluie (A rainy afternoon)

Act 3 · Les vignes et le doute (Vineyards and doubt) · B1

Episode 11 · Dans les vignes du Beaujolais (In the Beaujolais vineyards)
Episode 12 · Un coup de téléphone (A phone call)
Episode 13 · Le message (The message)
Episode 14 · Pardon, sur le quai (Sorry, on the quay)
Episode 15 · Au Gros Caillou (At the Gros Caillou)

Act 4 · La réponse (The answer) · B1

Episode 16 · La rencontre (Meeting Jacques)
Episode 17 · Le secret de Lucienne (Lucienne's secret)
Episode 18 · La lettre jamais envoyée (The unsent letter)
Episode 19 · On prépare un dîner (Planning a dinner)
Episode 20 · Un nouveau départ (A new beginning)

Act 1 · L'arrivée (Arrival)

Level A2

Episode 1 · L'emménagement (Moving in)



On a Saturday afternoon Maya, 30, is carrying boxes up to her late grandmother's flat on the fourth floor of an old building on rue Dumenge, in Lyon's Croix-Rousse. There's no lift. Théo, who runs the bookshop on the ground floor, comes out to help her.

Maya Excusez-moi, monsieur ! Vous pouvez m'aider ? Il n'y a pas d'ascenseur.
Excuse me! Could you help me? There's no lift. (US: elevator)

Théo Avec plaisir ! Je m'appelle Théo. J'ai la librairie, en bas.
With pleasure! My name's Théo. I have the bookshop downstairs. (US: bookstore)

Maya Enchantée. Moi, c'est Maya. J'habite au quatrième étage, maintenant.
Nice to meet you. I'm Maya. I live on the fourth floor now.

Théo Au quatrième ? Chez Mme Laurent ? Vous êtes de la famille ?
On the fourth? At Mme Laurent's? Are you family?

Maya Oui, c'est l'appartement de ma grand-mère. Je viens de Londres.
Yes, it's my grandmother's flat (US: apartment). I'm from London.

Théo Je suis désolé. Je pense souvent à Simone. Un roman chaque samedi, toujours !
I'm so sorry. I often think of Simone. A novel every Saturday, always!

Maya Merci. Je suis graphiste, alors je travaille ici, avec mon ordinateur.
Thank you. I'm a graphic designer, so I work from here, on my computer.

Théo Bon, je porte ce carton. Vous portez le sac ? On monte !
Right, I'll carry this box. Can you carry the bag? Up we go!

Maya Voilà la cuisine. Vous pouvez poser le carton sur le comptoir.
Here's the kitchen. You can put the box on the counter.

Théo Ouf ! Il est lourd, ce carton. Qu'est-ce qu'il y a dedans ?
Phew! It's heavy, this box. What's in it?

Maya Des livres, bien sûr ! Oh… le carreau bleu bouge.
Books, of course! Oh… the blue tile is moving.

Théo Attendez… il y a quelque chose derrière le carreau. Une petite boîte en fer !
Wait… there's something behind the tile. A little tin box!

Words from this episode

- **Vous pouvez m'aider ?** *(voo poo-vay meh-day)* — Could you help me? (polite)
- **Avec plaisir** *(ah-vek pleh-zeer)* — With pleasure
- **Je m'appelle Théo** *(zhuh mah-pel tay-oh)* — My name's Théo (literally: I call myself Théo)
- **Enchantée** *(ahN-shahN-tay)* — Nice to meet you (Maya writes Enchantée because she's a woman; it sounds the same as Enchanté)
- **J'habite** *(zhah-beet)* — I live
- **au quatrième étage** *(oh kah-tree-yem ay-tahzh)* — on the fourth floor (quatre → quatrième)
- **Je viens de Londres** *(zhuh vyaN duh lohNdr)* — I'm from London (literally: I come from London)
- **je travaille** *(zhuh trah-vahy)* — I work
- **je porte ce carton** *(zhuh port suh kar-tohN)* — I'll carry this box (the present often means 'I'll…' for something you're about to do)
- **On monte** *(ohN mohNt)* — Up we go (literally: we go up)

Notice: Present-tense endings: je porte, vous portez

Théo says Je porte ce carton and asks Maya Vous portez le sac ? The stem port- stays the same; only the ending changes: -e for je, -ez for vous. Travailler works the same way: je travaille, vous travaillez.

See the table: Grammar tables, Present-tense endings.

Episode 2 · Les lettres de J. (The letters from J.)



On Sunday morning Théo comes up to Maya's flat with his toolbox to fix the loose blue tile. On the kitchen table is the little tin box from behind it. Inside are old letters in black ink and one envelope in Simone's blue ink.

Maya Bonjour, Théo ! Entrez. La boîte est sur la table.
Morning, Théo! Come in. The box is on the table.

Théo Bonjour, Maya. J'ai ma boîte à outils pour le carreau. Vous l'ouvrez ?
Morning, Maya. I've got my toolbox for the tile. Are you going to open it?

Maya Oui. Il y a des lettres… trois lettres, signées J.
Yes. There are letters… three letters, signed J.

Théo Et il y a une enveloppe : « Pour J. » C'est l'écriture de Simone ?
And there's an envelope: 'For J.' Is that Simone's handwriting?

Maya Oui, l'encre bleue de Mamie. Mais elle est fermée. Je ne l'ouvre pas : ce n'est pas à moi.
Yes, Mamie's blue ink. But it's sealed. I'm not opening it: it isn't mine.

Théo Vous avez raison. On lit la première lettre ?
You're right. Shall we read the first letter?

Maya « Depuis samedi, je pense à toi tout le temps. » Et puis : le Café des Canuts, un foulard bleu, Lucienne…
'Since Saturday I've been thinking about you all the time.' And then: the Café des Canuts, a blue scarf, Lucienne…

Théo Qui est Lucienne ? Une amie de Simone, peut-être ?
Who's Lucienne? A friend of Simone's, maybe?

Maya Je ne sais pas. J. écrit : « Je t'attends à dix heures, en haut de la montée de la Grande-Côte. »
I don't know. J. writes: 'I'll wait for you at ten o'clock at the top of the montée de la Grande-Côte.'

Théo La Grande-Côte, c'est ici, sur la colline ! Et la troisième lettre ?
The Grande-Côte is right here, on the hill! And the third letter?

Maya « Si ta réponse est oui, retrouve-moi samedi, à dix-huit heures, au Café des Canuts. »
'If your answer is yes, meet me on Saturday at six p.m. at the Café des Canuts.'

Théo Et là : « Mais je suis prêt à tout recommencer avec toi, là-bas. » Prêt, pas prête. J. est donc un homme.
And here: 'But I'm ready to start everything again with you, over there.' Prêt, not prête. So J. is a man.

Maya « Je t'attendrai jusqu'au dernier moment. » Le Café des Canuts… Vous connaissez ?
'I'll wait for you until the very last moment.' The Café des Canuts… Do you know it?

Théo Non. Mais on va chercher.
No. But we're going to look for it.

Words from this episode

- **Vous l'ouvrez ?** *(voo loo-vray)* — Are you going to open it? (ouvrir: to open)
- **Il y a des lettres** *(eel ee ah day let-ruh)* — There are (some) letters (des: plural of un / une)
- **trois lettres** *(trwah let-ruh)* — three letters
- **On lit la première lettre ?** *(ohN lee lah pruh-myair let-ruh)* — Shall we read the first letter? (lire: to read)
- **Qui est Lucienne ?** *(kee eh lew-syen)* — Who's Lucienne?
- **Je ne sais pas** *(zhuh nuh seh pah)* — I don't know
- **J. écrit** *(zhee ay-kree)* — J. writes (écrire: to write)
- **Je t'attendrai** *(zhuh tah-tahN-dray)* — I'll wait for you (attendre: to wait for, no 'for' in French)
- **Vous connaissez ?** *(voo koh-neh-say)* — Do you know it? (connaître: to know a place or a person)
- **on va chercher** *(ohN vah shair-shay)* — we're going to look (chercher: to look for)

Notice: Il y a un, une, des: there is, there are

Maya says Il y a des lettres and Théo adds Il y a une enveloppe. Il y a means both 'there is' and 'there are', and it never changes. After it, use un (masculine), une (feminine) or des (plural).

See the table: Grammar tables, Indefinite articles: a, an, some.

Episode 3 · Une adresse disparue (An address that's gone)



On Sunday afternoon Théo shows Maya the Croix-Rousse, the old silk weavers' hill. They walk through a traboule to the Cour des Voraces and look across the Saône at Fourvière. Then they go to find the Café des Canuts on the place de la Croix-Rousse.

Théo Venez, Maya. On va prendre une traboule. Vous allez voir, c'est magique.
Come on, Maya. We're going to take a traboule. You'll see, it's magical.

Maya Une traboule ? Ça veut dire quoi ?
A traboule? What does that mean?

Théo Un passage à travers les immeubles. Et voilà la Cour des Voraces !
It's a passage through the buildings. And here's the Cour des Voraces!

Maya C'est très beau ! Et pourquoi les plafonds sont si hauts, chez moi ?
It's beautiful! And why are the ceilings so high in my flat?

Théo Pour les métiers à tisser ! Ici, c'est le quartier de la soie, la colline qui travaille.
For the looms! This is the silk district, the hill that works.

Maya Et en face, de l'autre côté de la Saône, c'est Fourvière ?
And opposite, on the other side of the Saône, that's Fourvière?

Théo Oui, la colline qui prie. Un jour, on va monter là-haut, à la basilique.
Yes, the hill that prays. One day we'll go up there, to the basilica.

Maya Comme Simone et J. ! Bon, où est le Café des Canuts ?
Like Simone and J.! Right, where's the Café des Canuts?

Théo Sur mon vieux plan de Lyon, il est sur la place de la Croix-Rousse. On y va ?
On my old map of Lyon, it's on the place de la Croix-Rousse. Shall we go?

Maya Voilà la place. Mais… à cette adresse, il y a un opticien !
Here's the square. But… at this address there's an optician's!

Théo Alors le Café des Canuts n'existe plus… Je suis désolé, Maya.
So the Café des Canuts doesn't exist any more… I'm sorry, Maya.

Maya Ce n'est pas grave. Mais qu'est-ce qu'on va faire, maintenant ?
Never mind. But what are we going to do now?

Théo On va demander à M. Rossi. Il buvait son café là-bas.
We're going to ask M. Rossi. He used to drink his coffee there.

Words from this episode

- **On va prendre une traboule** *(ohN vah prahNdr ewn trah-bool)* — We're going to take a traboule (a covered passage through the buildings)
- **Vous allez voir** *(voo‿zah-lay vwahr)* — You'll see (literally: you're going to see)
- **Ça veut dire quoi ?** *(sah vuh deer kwah)* — What does that mean?
- **pourquoi** *(poor-kwah)* — why
- **en face** *(ahN fahs)* — opposite, across the way
- **on va monter là-haut** *(ohN vah mohN-tay lah-oh)* — we're going to go up there
- **On y va ?** *(ohN‿nee vah)* — Shall we go?
- **Je suis désolé** *(zhuh swee day-zoh-lay)* — I'm sorry (Théo is a man: désolé; Maya would write désolée)
- **Ce n'est pas grave** *(suh neh pah grahv)* — Never mind / It doesn't matter (spoken: C'est pas grave)
- **On va demander à M. Rossi** *(ohN vah duh-mahN-day ah muh-syuh roh-see)* — We're going to ask M. Rossi (demander à quelqu'un)

Notice: Aller + infinitive: the near future

Théo makes plans with aller + an infinitive: On va prendre une traboule, Vous allez voir, On va demander à M. Rossi. Conjugate aller (je vais, vous allez, on va) and leave the second verb in the infinitive. It's the everyday way to say what's going to happen; the table's Watch-out note compares it with the futur simple.

See the table: Grammar tables, Futur simple: endings and irregular stems.

Episode 4 · Le voisin de la cour (The neighbour in the courtyard)



On Monday evening M. Rossi, who lives on the ground floor, is watering his geraniums in the courtyard. Maya comes down with a lot of questions about the Café des Canuts. M. Rossi has lived on the Croix-Rousse for a long time and loves to chat.

M. Rossi Bonsoir, mademoiselle ! Vous êtes la petite-fille de Simone, n'est-ce pas ?
Good evening! You're Simone's granddaughter, aren't you?

Maya Oui, je suis Maya. Bonsoir, monsieur Rossi. Comment allez-vous ?
Yes, I'm Maya. Good evening, M. Rossi. How are you?

M. Rossi Très bien, merci. J'arrose mes géraniums. Et vous ?
Very well, thanks. I'm watering my geraniums. And you?

Maya Bien, merci. Une question : est-ce que vous connaissez le Café des Canuts ?
Fine, thanks. A question: do you know the Café des Canuts?

M. Rossi Bien sûr ! J'ai bu mon café là-bas pendant des années.
Of course! I drank my coffee there for years.

Maya Et quand est-ce que le café a fermé ?
And when did the café close?

M. Rossi En quatre-vingt-cinq. Il est fermé depuis quarante ans, mademoiselle.
In eighty-five. It's been closed for forty years.

Maya Qui venait au café ? Les gens du quartier ?
Who used to go to the café? People from the neighbourhood? (US: neighborhood)

M. Rossi Les canuts, et les typographes de l'imprimerie Delorme, sur le quai Saint-Vincent.
The silk weavers, and the typesetters from the Delorme printing works, on the quai Saint-Vincent.

Maya Delorme ? Mais J. écrit « Monsieur Delorme » dans une lettre !
Delorme? But J. writes 'Monsieur Delorme' in one of the letters!

M. Rossi Alors votre J. était peut-être typographe. Pourquoi est-ce que vous cherchez ce monsieur ?
Then maybe your J. was a typesetter. Why are you looking for this man?

Maya C'est une histoire de ma grand-mère. Qui peut m'aider, à votre avis ?
It's a story about my grandmother. Who could help me, do you think?

M. Rossi Demandez à Mme Berthier, au cinquième. Elle sait tout… mais elle ne dit rien.
Ask Mme Berthier, on the fifth floor. She knows everything… but she says nothing.

Words from this episode

- **Comment allez-vous ?** *(koh-mahN‿tah-lay voo)* — How are you? (polite)
- **Et vous ?** *(ay voo)* — And you? (polite)
- **est-ce que vous connaissez** *(es-kuh voo koh-neh-say)* — do you know (est-ce que turns a sentence into a question)
- **J'ai bu mon café** *(zhay bew mohN kah-fay)* — I drank my coffee (boire → bu)
- **pendant des années** *(pahN-dahN day‿zah-nay)* — for years
- **Quand est-ce que** *(kahN‿tes-kuh)* — When…? (question word + est-ce que)
- **le café a fermé** *(luh kah-fay ah fair-may)* — the café closed
- **depuis quarante ans** *(duh-pwee kah-rahN-tahN)* — for forty years (and still now)
- **Qui venait** *(kee vuh-neh)* — Who used to come (venir)
- **Elle sait tout** *(el seh too)* — She knows everything (savoir)

Notice: Question words: quand, qui, pourquoi

Maya asks Quand est-ce que le café a fermé ? and Qui venait au café ? M. Rossi asks back Pourquoi est-ce que vous cherchez ce monsieur ? Put the question word first, then est-ce que and an ordinary sentence. When qui is the subject, you don't need est-ce que.

See the table: Grammar tables, Question words.

Episode 5 · Une porte qui se ferme (A door that closes)



On Tuesday evening Théo climbs to the fifth floor to bring Mme Berthier, 88, the detective novel she ordered from his bookshop. She has lived in the building since 1960 and knew Simone well. Théo wants to ask her about 1962, but she doesn't want to remember.

Théo Bonsoir, madame Berthier ! Je vous apporte votre roman policier.
Good evening, Mme Berthier! I've brought you your detective novel.

Mme Berthier Ah, mon petit Théo ! Merci. Entrez, mais ne restez pas longtemps.
Ah, my dear Théo! Thank you. Come in, but don't stay long.

Théo Juste une question. Vous vous souvenez de Simone à vingt ans ?
Just one question. Do you remember Simone at twenty?

Mme Berthier Simone… Bien sûr. Toujours son foulard bleu, et toujours ce rire !
Simone… Of course. Always that blue scarf, and always that laugh!

Théo Et un garçon, en mille neuf cent soixante-deux ? Un certain J. ?
And a boy, in 1962? A certain J.?

Mme Berthier Un garçon de l'imprimerie, oui. Grand, timide…
A boy from the printing works, yes. Tall, shy…

Théo Comment il s'appelle ? Vous savez son nom ?
What's he called? Do you know his name?

Mme Berthier Non. Je ne sais rien, je ne connais personne. C'est loin, tout ça.
No. I don't know anything, I don't know anyone. That was all a long time ago.

Théo Mais madame, vous habitez ici depuis soixante-six ans !
But madame, you've lived here for sixty-six years!

Mme Berthier Et alors ? Je ne regarde jamais en arrière. Allez à la bibliothèque, à la Part-Dieu.
So what? I never look back. Go to the library, at Part-Dieu.

Théo D'accord. Oh… Dans ce livre, il y a une dédicace : « À Lucienne ».
All right. Oh… In this book there's an inscription: 'To Lucienne'.

Mme Berthier Ce n'est rien. Il est tard, Théo. Je suis fatiguée.
It's nothing. It's late, Théo. I'm tired.

Théo Vous vous appelez Lucienne, n'est-ce pas ?
Your name is Lucienne, isn't it?

Mme Berthier Bonsoir, monsieur Garnier.
Good night, Monsieur Garnier. (She uses his surname: the conversation is over.)

Words from this episode

- **Je vous apporte** *(zhuh voo‿zah-port)* — I've brought you (literally: I bring you)
- **ne restez pas longtemps** *(nuh res-tay pah lohN-tahN)* — don't stay long
- **Vous vous souvenez de Simone** *(voo voo soov-nay duh see-mun)* — Do you remember Simone (se souvenir de)
- **Vous savez son nom ?** *(voo sah-vay sohN nohN)* — Do you know his name? (savoir: to know a fact)
- **Je ne sais rien** *(zhuh nuh seh ryaN)* — I don't know anything (ne… rien: nothing)
- **je ne connais personne** *(zhuh nuh koh-neh pair-sun)* — I don't know anyone (ne… personne: nobody)
- **Je ne regarde jamais en arrière** *(zhuh nuh ruh-gard zhah-meh ahN‿nah-ryair)* — I never look back (ne… jamais: never)
- **Je suis fatiguée** *(zhuh swee fah-tee-gay)* — I'm tired (a woman writes fatiguée; it sounds the same)
- **Vous vous appelez Lucienne** *(voo voo‿zah-play lew-syen)* — Your name is Lucienne (s'appeler: vous vous appelez)
- **Bonsoir** *(bohN-swahr)* — Good evening (here also: good night, goodbye)

Notice: Negative words: ne… rien, ne… personne, ne… jamais

Mme Berthier shuts Théo out with negatives: Je ne sais rien, je ne connais personne, Je ne regarde jamais en arrière. Ne goes before the verb, and rien, personne or jamais takes the place of pas after it. In speech the ne often disappears (Je sais rien), but keep it when you write.

See the table: Grammar tables, Negative words.

Act 2 · L'enquête (The search)

Level A2

Episode 6 · Aux archives (In the archives)



On Thursday Maya goes to the Part-Dieu library while Théo minds the bookshop. M. Faure, an archivist, finds a 1962 issue of Le Progrès on microfilm about the Delorme printing works. Under a staff photo, the caption gives the workers' names.

Maya Bonjour, monsieur. Vous pouvez m'aider ? Je cherche un article sur l'imprimerie Delorme.
Hello. Can you help me? I'm looking for an article about the Delorme printing works.

M. Faure Bien sûr. L'imprimerie Delorme, quai Saint-Vincent ? Elle a fermé en mille neuf cent soixante-quinze.
Of course. The Delorme printing works, on the quai Saint-Vincent? It closed in 1975.

Maya Ah bon ? Je voudrais savoir qui travaillait là-bas en soixante-deux.
Really? I'd like to know who worked there in '62.

M. Faure Alors, j'ai trouvé ce microfilm. Le Progrès du huit septembre mille neuf cent soixante-deux.
Right, I've found this microfilm. Le Progrès of 8 September 1962.

Maya Oh ! Il y a une photo… « L'imprimerie Delorme a cent ans ».
Oh! There's a photo… 'The Delorme printing works is a hundred years old.'

M. Faure Oui, c'est toute l'équipe, devant l'atelier. Et sous la photo, il y a les noms.
Yes, it's the whole team, in front of the workshop. And under the photo there are the names.

Maya Et ces typographes, qu'est-ce qu'ils sont devenus ?
And these typesetters, what became of them?

M. Faure Après la fermeture, certains sont partis, d'autres sont restés à Lyon.
After it closed, some left and others stayed in Lyon.

Maya Je cherche un homme. Son prénom commence par J.
I'm looking for a man. His first name begins with J.

M. Faure Une seule lettre, c'est peu ! Mais vous avez de la chance : trois noms commencent par J.
Just one letter, that's not much to go on! But you're in luck: three names begin with J.

Maya Merci beaucoup. Vous pouvez faire une copie de la page ?
Thank you very much. Could you make a copy of the page?

M. Faure Je l'ai déjà imprimée. Tenez, lisez les noms.
I've already printed it. Here you are, read the names.

Maya Jean Cordier, Jacques Perrin, Joseph Lambert. Trois J.
Jean Cordier, Jacques Perrin, Joseph Lambert. Three J.s.

Words from this episode

- **Vous pouvez m'aider ?** *(voo poo-vay meh-day)* — Can you help me? (polite)
- **Je cherche** *(zhuh shairsh)* — I'm looking for (chercher: no 'for' in French)
- **Elle a fermé** *(el ah fair-may)* — It closed (fermer takes avoir)
- **mille neuf cent soixante-quinze** *(meel nuhf sahN swah-sahNt-kaNz)* — 1975 (years are said in full: one thousand nine hundred seventy-five)
- **j'ai trouvé** *(zhay troo-vay)* — I've found / I found
- **huit septembre** *(wee sep-tahNbr)* — 8 September (no capital on months)
- **qu'est-ce qu'ils sont devenus ?** *(kes-keel sohN duh-vuh-new)* — what became of them? (devenir takes être)
- **certains sont partis** *(sair-taN sohN par-tee)* — some left (partir takes être)
- **d'autres sont restés** *(doh-truh sohN res-tay)* — others stayed (rester takes être)
- **Merci beaucoup** *(mair-see boh-koo)* — Thank you very much

Notice: Être or avoir in the passé composé

M. Faure says L'imprimerie a fermé: most verbs, like fermer, make the passé composé with avoir. Verbs of coming, going, staying and becoming take être, and their participle agrees with the subject: certains sont partis, d'autres sont restés, qu'est-ce qu'ils sont devenus ?

See the table: Grammar tables, Verbs that take être in the passé composé.

Episode 7 · La photo (The photo)



On Friday evening Théo and Maya sort her grandmother's books for the bookshop. A photo falls out of Le Petit Prince: Simone and a tall young man by the Saône in June 1962. They read the first letter again, and Théo suggests they say tu.

Théo Encore un carton de livres ! Votre grand-mère lisait beaucoup.
Another box of books! Your grandmother read a lot.

Maya Oh, regardez : Le Petit Prince. C'était mon livre préféré.
Oh, look: Le Petit Prince. It was my favourite book. (US: favorite)

Théo Attendez, quelque chose est tombé du livre. Une photo !
Wait, something's fallen out of the book. A photo!

Maya C'est Mamie ! Elle était si jeune… Et elle riait.
It's Mamie! She was so young… And she was laughing.

Théo Et le grand jeune homme, à côté d'elle ? Regardez derrière.
And the tall young man next to her? Look on the back.

Maya « Toi et moi, quai Saint-Antoine, juin mille neuf cent soixante-deux. J. »
'You and me, quai Saint-Antoine, June 1962. J.'

Théo C'est lui, J. ! Relisez la première lettre, maintenant.
It's him, J.! Read the first letter again, now.

Maya « Au Café des Canuts, il pleuvait. Tu avais un foulard bleu… » Le voilà, son foulard.
'At the Café des Canuts, it was raining. You had a blue scarf…' There it is, her scarf.

Théo On lit les lettres d'amour de votre grand-mère ensemble… On peut se tutoyer, non ?
We're reading your grandmother's love letters together… We could say tu to each other, couldn't we?

Maya Oui. Tu as raison. Merci, Théo… pour tout ça.
Yes. You're right. Thank you, Théo… for all this.

Théo De rien. Tu le reconnais, cet endroit, derrière eux ?
You're welcome. Do you recognise that place, behind them? (US: recognize)

Maya On dirait un marché, au bord de la Saône. Il y a un panneau…
It looks like a market, by the Saône. There's a sign…

Théo « BRUN, primeurs »… Les Brun ! Ils sont encore au marché de la Croix-Rousse.
'BRUN, greengrocers'… The Bruns! They're still at the Croix-Rousse market.

Words from this episode

- **lisait beaucoup** *(lee-zeh boh-koo)* — used to read a lot (imparfait: a habit)
- **C'était mon livre préféré** *(say-teh mohN lee-vruh pray-fay-ray)* — It was my favourite book (c'était: imparfait of c'est)
- **quelque chose est tombé** *(kel-kuh shohz eh tohN-bay)* — something fell (tomber takes être)
- **elle riait** *(el ree-yeh)* — she was laughing (rire, imparfait)
- **il pleuvait** *(eel pluh-veh)* — it was raining (pleuvoir, imparfait)
- **Tu avais un foulard bleu** *(tew ah-veh uhN foo-lar bluh)* — You had a blue scarf (imparfait: a description)
- **On peut se tutoyer, non ?** *(ohN puh suh tew-twah-yay, nohN)* — Shall we say tu? (tutoyer: to say tu; vouvoyer: to say vous)
- **Tu as raison** *(tew ah reh-zohN)* — You're right (avoir raison; now with tu)
- **Tu le reconnais** *(tew luh ruh-koh-neh)* — Do you recognise it? (US: recognize)
- **cet endroit** *(set ahN-drwah)* — that place (ce becomes cet before a vowel)

Notice: The imparfait: how things were

The letter paints the scene: Au Café des Canuts, il pleuvait. Tu avais un foulard bleu. The imparfait (pleuvait, avais, riait, était) describes the background in the past: the weather, how people looked, what was going on. For a single event, Théo uses the passé composé: quelque chose est tombé.

See the table: Grammar tables, Imparfait: how things were, what used to happen.

Episode 8 · Le marchand se souvient (The market seller remembers)

On Saturday morning Maya buys figs at the Croix-Rousse market and shows the photo to M. Brun, who is 84. In 1962 he worked at his parents' stall on the quai Saint-Antoine. He remembers Simone, and the young man too.

M. Brun Bonjour, mademoiselle ! Qu'est-ce qu'il vous faut, ce matin ?
Morning! What can I get you today? (literally: what do you need this morning?)

Maya Bonjour, monsieur. Je voudrais des figues, s'il vous plaît. Un demi-kilo.
Morning. I'd like some figs, please. Half a kilo.

M. Brun Voilà, elles sont très belles cette semaine. Et avec ça ?
Here you are, they're lovely this week. Anything else?

Maya C'est tout, merci. Excusez-moi, vous êtes monsieur Brun ?
That's all, thanks. Excuse me, are you Monsieur Brun?

M. Brun Raymond Brun, oui. Mais c'est mon fils qui tient le stand, maintenant.
Raymond Brun, yes. But it's my son who runs the stall now.

Maya Regardez cette photo. C'était le stand de vos parents ?
Look at this photo. Was this your parents' stall?

M. Brun Quai Saint-Antoine… il y a soixante-quatre ans ! J'avais vingt ans, à l'époque.
The quai Saint-Antoine… sixty-four years ago! I was twenty back then.

Maya Et ces deux jeunes, vous les reconnaissez ?
And these two young people, do you recognise them? (US: recognize)

M. Brun Elle, oui ! La fille du canut de la rue Dumenge. Elle venait le dimanche avec son foulard.
Her, yes! The silk weaver's daughter from rue Dumenge. She used to come on Sundays in her scarf.

Maya C'était ma grand-mère, Simone. Et lui ? Vous vous souvenez de lui ?
That was my grandmother, Simone. And him? Do you remember him?

M. Brun Le grand, là… C'était Jacques, de l'imprimerie. Ils achetaient des pêches, tous les deux.
The tall one… That was Jacques, from the printing works. They used to buy peaches, the two of them.

Maya Jacques ! Vous connaissez son nom de famille ?
Jacques! Do you know his surname? (US: last name)

M. Brun Perrin, je pense… Il habite montée Saint-Sébastien, je crois. Allez-y de ma part !
Perrin, I think… He lives on the montée Saint-Sébastien, I believe. Go and see him, and say I sent you!

Words from this episode

- **Je voudrais des figues** *(zhuh voo-dreh day feeg)* — I'd like some figs (polite)
- **C'est tout** *(seh too)* — That's all
- **Excusez-moi** *(eks-kew-zay mwah)* — Excuse me
- **il y a soixante-quatre ans** *(eel ee ah swah-sahNt-kah-trahN)* — sixty-four years ago (il y a + time = ago)
- **J'avais vingt ans** *(zhah-veh vaN‿tahN)* — I was twenty (age uses avoir: j'ai, j'avais)
- **vous les reconnaissez ?** *(voo lay ruh-koh-neh-say)* — do you recognise them? (US: recognize)
- **Elle venait le dimanche** *(el vuh-neh luh dee-mahNsh)* — She used to come on Sundays (imparfait: a habit; le dimanche = every Sunday)
- **Vous vous souvenez de lui ?** *(voo voo soo-vuh-nay duh lwee)* — Do you remember him? (se souvenir de)
- **Ils achetaient des pêches** *(eel‿zahsh-teh day pesh)* — They used to buy peaches
- **Allez-y de ma part** *(ah-lay-zee duh mah par)* — Go and see him, say I sent you (de ma part: from me)

Notice: Il y a + time: 'ago'

M. Brun looks at the photo and says il y a soixante-quatre ans: sixty-four years ago. Il y a + a length of time means 'ago'. À l'époque means 'back then', and le dimanche (with le) means 'on Sundays', every week, which is why it goes with the imparfait: elle venait le dimanche.

See the table: Grammar tables, Common time expressions.

Episode 9 · Le mauvais Jacques (The wrong Jacques)



On Monday Maya visits M. Perrin on the montée Saint-Sébastien. He is 86, a little hard of hearing, kind and funny, and he worked at the Delorme printing works. He looks at the photo and laughs.

M. Perrin Bonjour, mademoiselle ! C'est monsieur Brun qui vous envoie ?
Hello! Monsieur Brun sent you? (literally: it's Monsieur Brun who's sending you?)

Maya Oui. Je suis la petite-fille de Simone Morel, de la rue Dumenge.
Yes. I'm Simone Morel's granddaughter, from rue Dumenge.

M. Perrin Pardon ? Vous pouvez répéter ? J'entends mal, vous savez.
Sorry? Could you say that again? I don't hear very well, you know.

Maya Bien sûr. La petite-fille de Simone Morel.
Of course. Simone Morel's granddaughter.

M. Perrin Ah, la petite Simone ! Entrez, entrez. Qu'est-ce que je peux faire pour vous ?
Ah, little Simone! Come in, come in. What can I do for you?

Maya Monsieur Brun dit que vous êtes le Jacques de cette photo. Regardez.
Monsieur Brun says you're the Jacques in this photo. Look.

M. Perrin Moi ? Ha ! Non, je n'étais pas aussi beau, mademoiselle.
Me? Ha! No, I was never that handsome, mademoiselle. (literally: I wasn't as handsome)

Maya Ce n'est pas vous ? Mais vous vous appelez Jacques…
It isn't you? But your name's Jacques…

M. Perrin Jacques ? Lequel ? Il y avait deux Jacques chez Delorme !
Jacques? Which one? There were two Jacques at Delorme's!

Maya Celui de la photo. Le grand, à côté de ma grand-mère.
The one in the photo. The tall one, next to my grandmother.

M. Perrin Ah, l'autre Jacques ! Grand et timide. Il a quitté Delorme en soixante-deux.
Ah, the other Jacques! Tall and shy. He left Delorme's in '62.

Maya Vous vous souvenez de son nom de famille ?
Do you remember his surname? (US: last name)

M. Perrin Non, je suis désolé. Il est parti au Canada… et il n'est jamais revenu, je crois.
No, I'm sorry. He left for Canada… and he never came back, I think.

Words from this episode

- **qui vous envoie** *(kee voo‿zahN-vwah)* — who sends you (envoyer)
- **Pardon** *(par-dohN)* — Sorry? / Pardon? (asking someone to repeat)
- **J'entends mal** *(zhahN-tahN mahl)* — I don't hear well (entendre: to hear)
- **je n'étais pas aussi beau** *(zhuh nay-teh pah oh-see boh)* — I wasn't that handsome (être, imparfait)
- **Lequel ?** *(luh-kel)* — Which one? (masculine; laquelle for a feminine noun)
- **Celui de la photo** *(suh-lwee duh lah foh-toh)* — The one in the photo (celui: masculine)
- **Il a quitté Delorme** *(eel ah kee-tay duh-lorm)* — He left Delorme's (quitter + a place takes avoir)
- **Vous vous souvenez de son nom de famille ?** *(voo voo soo-vuh-nay duh sohN nohN duh fah-meey)* — Do you remember his surname? (US: last name)
- **Il est parti au Canada** *(eel eh par-tee oh kah-nah-dah)* — He left for Canada (partir takes être)
- **il n'est jamais revenu** *(eel neh zhah-meh ruh-vuh-new)* — he never came back (ne… jamais around être)

Notice: Lequel ? Which one?

When Maya says Jacques, M. Perrin asks Lequel ?: which one? Lequel stands for quel + a noun (quel Jacques ?) and agrees with it: lequel, laquelle, lesquels, lesquelles. Maya answers with celui de la photo, 'the one in the photo'.

See the table: Grammar tables, Lequel, laquelle: which one.

Episode 10 · Un après-midi de pluie (A rainy afternoon)



On Saturday afternoon the rain drums on the skylight of La Page Tournée. Maya tells Théo she wants to stop looking for J., and they argue. Then Théo picks up the second letter under the lamp.

Maya Il fait un temps de chien… et moi, j'en ai marre. Je veux arrêter.
The weather's foul… and I'm fed up. I want to stop.

Théo Arrêter ? Pourquoi ? On sait qu'il s'appelle Jacques !
Stop? Why? We know his name's Jacques!

Maya Un Jacques parti au Canada il y a soixante-quatre ans. Le Canada, c'est immense !
A Jacques who left for Canada sixty-four years ago. Canada is huge!

Théo Je sais, mais on n'a pas fini.
I know, but we haven't finished.

Maya Il est peut-être mort, Théo. Et moi, j'ai un appartement à vider et une vie à Londres.
He may be dead, Théo. And I've got a flat to clear out and a life in London. (US: an apartment)

Théo Tu as décidé ça toute seule ? Moi, je crois que tu as peur.
You decided that all on your own? I think you're scared.

Maya N'importe quoi ! Toi, tu ne sais pas ce que c'est, perdre quelqu'un.
Rubbish! You don't know what it's like to lose someone. (US: nonsense)

Théo Si, je sais. Mon père est mort il y a trois ans.
Yes, I do. My father died three years ago.

Maya Oh… Théo. Je ne savais pas. Je suis désolée.
Oh… Théo. I didn't know. I'm sorry.

Théo Ce n'est pas grave. Après, moi aussi, j'avais le cafard. Je voulais tout arrêter.
It's all right. Afterwards, I felt low too. I wanted to give everything up.

Maya Et qu'est-ce qui t'a aidé ?
And what helped you?

Théo Les livres. Et les gens du quartier. Viens, regarde encore les lettres avec moi.
Books. And the people in the neighbourhood. Come on, look at the letters again with me. (US: neighborhood)

Maya D'accord. « Je suis chez mes parents, à la campagne… » Mais où ?
OK. 'I'm at my parents', in the country…' But where?

Théo Attends. Le cachet de la poste… Fleurie. Fleurie, dans le Beaujolais !
Wait. The postmark… Fleurie. Fleurie, in the Beaujolais!

Words from this episode

- **Il fait un temps de chien** *(eel feh uhN tahN duh shyaN)* — The weather's foul (literally: a dog's weather)
- **j'en ai marre** *(zhahN‿nay mar)* — I'm fed up (informal)
- **Tu as décidé** *(tew ah day-see-day)* — You decided / You've decided (décider)
- **je crois que tu as peur** *(zhuh krwah kuh tew ah puhr)* — I think you're scared (croire que; avoir peur)
- **N'importe quoi** *(naN-port kwah)* — Rubbish! / Nonsense!
- **Toi, tu ne sais pas** *(twah, tew nuh seh pah)* — You don't know (toi stresses 'you')
- **perdre quelqu'un** *(pair-druh kelk-uhN)* — to lose someone
- **Mon père est mort** *(mohN pair eh mor)* — My father died (mourir takes être)
- **j'avais le cafard** *(zhah-veh luh kah-far)* — I felt low (avoir le cafard; imparfait for a feeling)
- **le cachet de la poste** *(luh kah-sheh duh lah post)* — the postmark

Notice: Moi, toi: stressed pronouns for contrast

In the argument they put moi and toi in front: Et moi, j'ai un appartement à vider. Toi, tu ne sais pas… A stressed pronoun adds weight or contrast, and the normal subject (je, tu) still comes before the verb. You also use them after a preposition: avec moi.

See the table: Grammar tables, Stressed pronouns: moi, toi...

Act 3 · Les vignes et le doute (Vineyards and doubt)

Level B1

Episode 11 · Dans les vignes du Beaujolais (In the Beaujolais vineyards)



It's Sunday, the last day of the grape harvest in Fleurie, and long tables are being set out between the vines for the revole. Maya asks M. Dumas, a winegrower, about a family who had vines here long ago, while Théo picks grapes further down the row.

M. Dumas Bienvenue à Fleurie, mademoiselle ! C'est le dernier jour des vendanges.
Welcome to Fleurie! It's the last day of the grape harvest.

Maya Merci, monsieur. Je cherche une famille qui avait des vignes ici, il y a longtemps.
Thank you. I'm looking for a family who had vines here, a long time ago.

M. Dumas Ah bon ? Comment est-ce qu'elle s'appelait, cette famille ?
Really? What was the family called?

Maya Je ne sais pas. Le fils s'appelait Jacques. Il travaillait à Lyon quand il est parti au Canada.
I don't know (their name). The son was called Jacques. He was working in Lyon when he left for Canada.

M. Dumas Jacques… au Canada ? Mais c'est le fils Vial ! Il est parti en soixante-deux.
Jacques… in Canada? But that's the Vial boy! He left in sixty-two.

Maya Vial ? Vous le connaissez ? Ses parents avaient des vignes ici ?
Vial? Do you know him? His parents had vines here?

M. Dumas Oui, ces vignes-là, sur la colline. Mon père les a achetées en quatre-vingt-cinq.
Yes, those vines there, on the hill. My father bought them in eighty-five.

Maya Et Jacques ? Il est revenu en France ?
And Jacques? Did he come back to France?

M. Dumas Oui, en deux mille un. Il vivait à Montréal, mais la France lui manquait.
Yes, in 2001. He was living in Montréal, but he missed France. (literally: France was missing to him)

Maya Il vient encore à Fleurie ?
Does he still come to Fleurie?

M. Dumas Tous les ans, pour la revole. Mais pas cette année : sa fille Odile a dit non, à cause de son cœur.
Every year, for the revole (the end-of-harvest meal). But not this year: his daughter Odile said no, because of his heart.

Maya Son cœur ? Où est-ce qu'il habite maintenant ?
His heart? Where does he live now?

M. Dumas Aux Tilleuls, à Caluire. Jacques Vial… Il est vivant, mademoiselle. Mais il est fragile.
At Les Tilleuls, in Caluire. Jacques Vial… He's alive. But he's frail.

Maya À Caluire… Mais c'est à dix minutes de chez moi !
In Caluire… But that's ten minutes from my place!

Words from this episode

- **il y a longtemps** *(eel ee ah lohN-tahN)* — a long time ago (il y a + time = ago)
- **Il travaillait à Lyon** *(eel trah-vah-yeh ah lee-ohN)* — He was working in Lyon (imparfait: the background)
- **il est parti au Canada** *(eel eh par-tee oh kah-nah-dah)* — he left for Canada (passé composé: the event)
- **Vous le connaissez ?** *(voo luh koh-neh-say)* — Do you know him?
- **Il est revenu en France** *(eel eh ruh-vuh-new ahN frahNs)* — He came back to France (en + a feminine country)
- **Il vivait à Montréal** *(eel vee-veh ah mohN-ray-ahl)* — He was living in Montréal (à + a city)
- **la France lui manquait** *(lah frahNs lwee mahN-keh)* — he missed France (literally: France was missing to him; lui = to him)
- **Tous les ans** *(too lay‿zahN)* — Every year
- **sa fille** *(sah feey)* — his daughter (sa: fille is feminine, whoever the parent is)

Notice: À, au, en: cities and countries

Maya says Il travaillait à Lyon quand il est parti au Canada, and M. Dumas answers Il est revenu en France and Il vivait à Montréal. Use à before a city, au before a masculine country (le Canada) and en before a feminine one (la France). The same word means both 'in' and 'to'.

See the table: Grammar tables, Cities and countries: à, en, au, aux.

Episode 12 · Un coup de téléphone (A phone call)



It's Monday morning and Maya is working upstairs in her flat. Downstairs in the bookshop, Théo phones the Résidence Les Tilleuls in Caluire, where Sabine, the receptionist, answers.

Sabine Résidence Les Tilleuls, bonjour. Sabine à l'appareil.
Les Tilleuls residence, good morning. Sabine speaking.

Théo Bonjour, madame. Je voudrais savoir si M. Jacques Vial habite chez vous.
Good morning. I'd like to know whether M. Jacques Vial lives with you.

Sabine Oui, M. Vial est un de nos résidents. C'est de la part de qui ?
Yes, M. Vial is one of our residents. Who's calling, please?

Théo Théo Garnier, de la librairie La Page Tournée. Je peux lui dire un mot ?
Théo Garnier, from La Page Tournée bookshop. Could I have a word with him?

Sabine Je suis désolée, monsieur. Pour les visites et les appels, il faut passer par sa fille.
I'm sorry. For visits and calls, you have to go through his daughter.

Théo Sa fille, Odile ? Est-ce que je peux lui laisser un message ?
His daughter, Odile? Can I leave her a message?

Sabine Bien sûr, mais elle est absente jusqu'à jeudi. C'est à quel sujet ?
Of course, but she's away until Thursday. What is it about?

Théo Une amie, Maya Clarke, a retrouvé des lettres. M. Vial les a écrites en soixante-deux.
A friend, Maya Clarke, has found some letters. M. Vial wrote them in sixty-two.

Sabine Des lettres… Je comprends. Et Garnier, comment ça s'écrit ?
Letters… I see. And Garnier, how do you spell that?

Théo G, A, R, N, I, E, R. Et voici le numéro de la librairie : zéro quatre, soixante-dix-huit…
G, A, R, N, I, E, R. And here's the bookshop's number: zero four, seventy-eight…

Sabine C'est noté. Je lui laisse le message jeudi matin. Je lui dis aussi que Mlle Clarke la cherche ?
That's noted. I'll leave her the message on Thursday morning. Shall I also tell her that Mlle Clarke is looking for her?

Théo Non… Pas encore. Le numéro, c'est seulement le mien.
No… Not yet. The number is just mine.

Words from this episode

- **je voudrais savoir** *(zhuh voo-dreh sah-vwahr)* — I'd like to know (polite)
- **Je peux lui dire un mot ?** *(zhuh puh lwee deer uhN moh)* — Could I have a word with him? (lui = to him)
- **il faut passer par sa fille** *(eel foh pah-say par sah feey)* — you have to go through his daughter
- **lui laisser un message** *(lwee leh-say uhN meh-sahzh)* — leave her a message (lui = to her)
- **jusqu'à jeudi** *(zhews-kah zhuh-dee)* — until Thursday
- **M. Vial les a écrites** *(muh-syuh vyahl lay‿zah ay-kreet)* — M. Vial wrote them (écrites agrees with les = les lettres)
- **comment ça s'écrit ?** *(koh-mahN sah say-kree)* — how do you spell that? (literally: how does that write itself?)
- **Je lui laisse le message** *(zhuh lwee les luh meh-sahzh)* — I'll leave her the message (lui replaces à Odile)
- **le mien** *(luh myaN)* — mine (le numéro → le mien)

Notice: Lui, leur: to him, to her, to them

Théo asks Je peux lui dire un mot ? about M. Vial and Est-ce que je peux lui laisser un message ? about Odile. Lui replaces à + one person, a man or a woman, and goes before the verb (here before the infinitive). For more than one person, use leur.

See the table: Grammar tables, Indirect object pronouns: me, lui, leur...

Episode 13 · Le message (The message)



It's Thursday, six o'clock in the evening. Maya is minding La Page Tournée while Théo delivers books, and the shop phone rings. Yanis, the chatty evening receptionist at Les Tilleuls, has a message for M. Garnier.

Yanis Bonsoir ! Ici Yanis, de la résidence Les Tilleuls. Je suis bien à La Page Tournée ?
Good evening! This is Yanis, from Les Tilleuls residence. Is this La Page Tournée?

Maya Les Tilleuls ? Oui… oui, c'est bien ici. Je vous écoute.
Les Tilleuls? Yes… yes, this is the right place. Go ahead. (literally: I'm listening to you)

Yanis J'ai un message pour M. Garnier, qui a appelé lundi. Vous le connaissez ?
I've got a message for M. Garnier, who called on Monday. Do you know him?

Maya Lundi ? Oui… je le connais. Je travaille avec lui.
Monday? Yes… I know him. I work with him.

Yanis Parfait. C'est de la part de Mme Odile Vial, la fille de M. Vial. Vous la connaissez aussi ?
Perfect. It's from Mme Odile Vial, M. Vial's daughter. Do you know her too?

Maya Non, je ne la connais pas. Mais je connais son père… enfin, ses lettres.
No, I don't know her. But I know her father… well, his letters.

Yanis Ah, d'accord ! Alors voilà : Mme Vial ne veut pas de visite cette semaine. Son père est trop fatigué.
Ah, right! So here it is: Mme Vial doesn't want a visit this week. Her father is too tired.

Maya Je comprends. Elle veut le protéger.
I understand. She wants to protect him.

Yanis Voilà. Mais elle voudrait voir M. Garnier samedi, seul. Elle l'a dit deux fois : seul !
That's it. But she'd like to see M. Garnier on Saturday, on his own. She said it twice: on his own!

Maya Seul ? Mais… M. Garnier a appelé lundi, vous êtes sûr ?
On his own? But… M. Garnier called on Monday, are you sure?

Yanis Oui, lundi matin. Ma collègue Sabine l'a noté. Il a laissé le numéro de la librairie.
Yes, Monday morning. My colleague Sabine wrote it down. He left the bookshop's number.

Maya Lundi… Il le sait depuis trois jours.
Monday… He's known for three days.

Yanis Pardon ? Vous pouvez lui donner le message, mademoiselle ?
Sorry? Can you give him the message?

Maya Merci, monsieur. Je vais le lui dire… moi-même.
Thank you. I'll tell him… myself.

Words from this episode

- **Je vous écoute** *(zhuh voo‿zay-koot)* — Go ahead (on the phone; literally: I'm listening to you)
- **qui a appelé lundi** *(kee ah ah-puh-lay luhN-dee)* — who called on Monday
- **Vous le connaissez ?** *(voo luh koh-neh-say)* — Do you know him? (le = him)
- **je ne la connais pas** *(zhuh nuh lah koh-neh pah)* — I don't know her (la = her; ne… pas goes around la + verb)
- **d'accord** *(dah-kor)* — right / OK
- **Elle veut le protéger** *(el vuh luh proh-tay-zhay)* — She wants to protect him (le goes before the infinitive)
- **depuis trois jours** *(duh-pwee trwah zhoor)* — for three days (and still now)
- **Pardon ?** *(par-dohN)* — Sorry? / Pardon?
- **Je vais le lui dire** *(zhuh veh luh lwee deer)* — I'm going to tell him (le = it, lui = to him)

Notice: Le, la, les: him, her, it, them

Yanis asks Vous le connaissez ? about M. Garnier, then Vous la connaissez aussi ? about Odile. Le (him, it) and la (her, it) replace the direct object and go before the verb; before a vowel they become l': Sabine l'a noté. In the negative, ne… pas goes around the pronoun and the verb together: Je ne la connais pas.

See the table: Grammar tables, Direct object pronouns: me, le, la...

Episode 14 · Pardon, sur le quai (Sorry, on the quay)



It's Thursday evening on the quay by the Saône, under the lights of Fourvière. Théo has found the bookshop empty and Maya walking by the river. She is angry; he has come to apologise.

Maya Tu ne me l'as pas dit. Tu l'as trouvé lundi, et tu ne me l'as pas dit.
You didn't tell me. You found him on Monday, and you didn't tell me.

Théo Je sais. Je suis désolé, Maya. J'avais peur.
I know. I'm sorry, Maya. I was scared.

Maya Peur de quoi ? Moi, j'étais en colère quand j'ai entendu le message.
Scared of what? I was angry when I heard the message.

Théo Jacques est fragile. Et je ne voulais pas voir une deuxième porte se fermer devant toi.
Jacques is frail. And I didn't want to see a second door close in your face.

Maya Alors tu as décidé pour moi. Tu voulais me protéger, c'est ça ?
So you decided for me. You wanted to protect me, is that it?

Théo Oui. C'était bête. Je l'ai compris ce soir, quand j'ai trouvé la librairie vide.
Yes. It was stupid. I realised it tonight, when I found the bookshop empty.

Maya C'est l'histoire de ma grand-mère, Théo. C'était à moi de décider.
It's my grandmother's story, Théo. It was up to me to decide.

Théo Tu as raison. Plus de secrets. Je te le promets.
You're right. No more secrets. I promise.

Maya Tu sais, l'enveloppe de Mamie… je ne l'ai toujours pas ouverte.
You know, Mamie's envelope… I still haven't opened it.

Théo Je sais. Tu me l'as dit le jour des lettres. Pourquoi pas ?
I know. You told me the day we found the letters. Why not?

Maya Parce qu'elle n'est pas à moi. Elle est pour J. Je veux la lui donner, à lui.
Because it isn't mine. It's for J. I want to give it to him, to him in person.

Théo Attends, un message… C'est Odile. Elle veut me voir samedi. Tu veux que je…
Hang on, a message… It's Odile. She wants to see me on Saturday. Do you want me to…

Maya Vas-y. Mais tu me racontes tout.
Go. But you tell me everything.

Words from this episode

- **Tu ne me l'as pas dit** *(tew nuh muh lah pah dee)* — You didn't tell me (me before l'; ne… pas around the group)
- **Je suis désolé** *(zhuh swee day-zoh-lay)* — I'm sorry (a woman writes désolée; it sounds the same)
- **J'avais peur** *(zhah-veh puhr)* — I was scared (avoir peur; imparfait for a feeling)
- **j'étais en colère** *(zhay-teh ahN koh-lair)* — I was angry (imparfait for a feeling)
- **tu as décidé pour moi** *(tew ah day-see-day poor mwah)* — you decided for me (passé composé: one action)
- **Je te le promets** *(zhuh tuh luh proh-meh)* — I promise (you) (te before le)
- **je ne l'ai toujours pas ouverte** *(zhuh nuh lay too-zhoor pah oo-vairt)* — I still haven't opened it (ouverte agrees with l' = l'enveloppe)
- **Je veux la lui donner** *(zhuh vuh lah lwee doh-nay)* — I want to give it to him (la before lui)
- **tu me racontes tout** *(tew muh rah-kohNt too)* — you tell me everything (raconter: to tell a story)

Notice: Me le, la lui: two pronouns together

Maya says Tu ne me l'as pas dit, and Théo answers Je te le promets. When two object pronouns meet, me or te comes before le or la, and le or la comes before lui: Je veux la lui donner. The pair sits before the verb (before avoir in the passé composé), and ne… pas goes around the whole group.

See the table: Grammar tables, Order of object pronouns.

Episode 15 · Au Gros Caillou (At the Gros Caillou)



It's Saturday evening at the Gros Caillou, the big boulder at the end of the boulevard, with the whole city lit up below. Théo has just met Odile and tells Maya everything, as he promised. Before they leave, Maya takes his hand.

Théo Voilà, je te raconte tout, comme promis. Odile était très inquiète.
Right, I'm telling you everything, as promised. Odile was very worried.

Maya Inquiète ? Pour son père ?
Worried? About her father?

Théo Oui. Son cœur est faible. Mais elle a dit oui : lundi, à quinze heures.
Yes. His heart is weak. But she said yes: Monday, at three o'clock.

Maya Lundi ! Mais pourquoi elle a dit oui ?
Monday! But why did she say yes?

Théo À cause d'une photo. Son père garde la photo d'une jeune femme dans son portefeuille.
Because of a photo. Her father keeps a photo of a young woman in his wallet.

Maya Une jeune femme… avec un foulard ?
A young woman… with a scarf?

Théo Odile ne sait pas. Mais elle est curieuse, maintenant. Et moi, je suis nerveux.
Odile doesn't know. But she's curious now. And me, I'm nervous.

Maya Moi aussi, je suis nerveuse. Et heureuse. Regarde la ville…
I'm nervous too. And happy. Look at the city…

Théo Le Rhône, Fourvière, la Croix-Rousse… Tu la trouves comment, notre colline ?
The Rhône, Fourvière, the Croix-Rousse… What do you think of it, our hill?

Maya Pour la première fois, je me sens chez moi ici.
For the first time, I feel at home here.

Théo Je suis content, Maya. Très content que tu sois venue.
I'm glad, Maya. Really glad you came.

Maya Moi aussi, je suis contente. Lundi, quinze heures… Tu viens avec moi ?
I'm glad too. Monday, three o'clock… Will you come with me?

Théo Oui. Je t'attendrai dans le jardin.
Yes. I'll wait for you in the garden.

Words from this episode

- **était très inquiète** *(ay-teh treh‿zaN-kyet)* — was very worried (inquiet → inquiète for a woman)
- **à quinze heures** *(ah kaN-zuhr)* — at three p.m. (15:00)
- **Son père garde la photo** *(sohN pair gard lah foh-toh)* — Her father keeps the photo
- **Et moi, je suis nerveux** *(ay mwah, zhuh swee nair-vuh)* — And me, I'm nervous (moi for emphasis; a man: nerveux)
- **je suis nerveuse** *(zhuh swee nair-vuhz)* — I'm nervous (a woman: nerveuse)
- **Tu la trouves comment ?** *(tew lah troov koh-mahN)* — What do you think of it? (literally: how do you find it?)
- **je me sens chez moi** *(zhuh muh sahN shay mwah)* — I feel at home (se sentir)
- **Tu viens avec moi ?** *(tew vyaN ah-vek mwah)* — Will you come with me?
- **Je t'attendrai** *(zhuh tah-tahN-dray)* — I'll wait for you (futur; J. wrote the same words in 1962)

Notice: Nerveux, nerveuse: adjectives agree

Théo says je suis nerveux; Maya answers je suis nerveuse… et heureuse. An adjective agrees with the person it describes: -eux becomes -euse for a woman, and many adjectives just add -e (content, contente). Odile était très inquiète follows the same idea: inquiet, inquiète.

See the table: Grammar tables, Regular agreement patterns.

Act 4 · La réponse (The answer)

Level B1

Episode 16 · La rencontre (Meeting Jacques)



On Monday at three, Maya walks into the linden garden of Les Tilleuls, a retirement home in Caluire. Jacques, eighty-seven, tall and tired, is waiting on a bench. She has the old photo in her hand and Simone's sealed envelope in her bag.

Maya Bonjour, monsieur. Excusez-moi, vous êtes monsieur Vial ?
Hello. Excuse me, are you Monsieur Vial?

Jacques Lui-même, mademoiselle. Asseyez-vous, je vous en prie. Vous êtes Maya, je crois ?
That's me, mademoiselle. Please, do sit down. You're Maya, I believe?

Maya Oui. Je suis la petite-fille de Simone Morel. Je voudrais vous montrer quelque chose.
Yes. I'm Simone Morel's granddaughter. I'd like to show you something.

Jacques Simone… Personne ne m'a dit ce nom depuis longtemps. Comment va-t-elle ?
Simone… Nobody has said that name to me for a long time. How is she?

Maya Je suis désolée. Elle est morte en janvier. Mais elle a gardé cette photo toute sa vie.
I'm sorry. She died in January. But she kept this photo all her life.

Jacques En janvier… Alors j'arrive trop tard, encore une fois. Montrez-moi, s'il vous plaît.
In January… So I'm too late, once again. Show me, please.

Maya C'est vous et elle, sur le quai Saint-Antoine, en juin mille neuf cent soixante-deux.
It's you and her, on the quai Saint-Antoine, in June 1962.

Jacques Attendez. Moi aussi, je la garde toujours sur moi. Lisez le dos : « Pour Jacques. Ne m'oublie pas. S. »
Wait. I always keep it on me too. Read the back: 'For Jacques. Don't forget me. S.'

Maya La même photo… Monsieur Vial, j'aimerais savoir. Qu'est-ce qui s'est passé, ce samedi de septembre ?
The same photo… Monsieur Vial, I'd like to know. What happened that Saturday in September?

Jacques Je l'ai attendue à dix-huit heures, comme dans ma lettre. J'ai attendu jusqu'au dernier moment.
I waited for her at six o'clock, as I said in my letter. I waited until the very last moment.

Maya Et ensuite, vous avez pris votre train… Vous ne lui avez jamais écrit ?
And then you took your train… You never wrote to her?

Jacques Si elle m'aime, elle écrira, je me disais. Aujourd'hui, j'aimerais seulement savoir pourquoi.
'If she loves me, she'll write,' I told myself. Today I'd just like to know why.

Maya Monsieur Vial… Est-ce que je pourrais revenir jeudi ?
Monsieur Vial… (her hand finds the sealed envelope in her bag) Could I come back on Thursday?

Jacques Jeudi ? Je vous attendrai, mademoiselle. Cette fois, je sais attendre.
Thursday? I'll wait for you, mademoiselle. This time, I know how to wait.

Words from this episode

- **Excusez-moi** *(eks-kew-zay mwah)* — Excuse me
- **je vous en prie** *(zhuh voo‿zahN pree)* — please (formal; here: 'do sit down')
- **Je voudrais** *(zhuh voo-dreh)* — I'd like (vouloir in the conditional: polite)
- **cette photo** *(set foh-toh)* — this photo (cette: feminine)
- **je la garde toujours sur moi** *(zhuh lah gard too-zhoor sewr mwah)* — I always keep it on me (garder)
- **Ne m'oublie pas** *(nuh moo-blee pah)* — Don't forget me (tu: written between lovers)
- **j'aimerais savoir** *(zhem-reh sah-vwahr)* — I'd like to know (aimer in the conditional)
- **J'ai attendu jusqu'au dernier moment** *(zhay ah-tahN-dew zhews-koh dair-nyay moh-mahN)* — I waited until the very last moment (attendre; the words of his 1962 letter)
- **je pourrais** *(zhuh poo-reh)* — I could (pouvoir in the conditional)
- **revenir jeudi** *(ruh-vuh-neer zhuh-dee)* — to come back on Thursday

Notice: The conditional for polite requests: je voudrais, je pourrais

Maya is talking to a stranger about something delicate, so she softens everything with the conditional: Je voudrais vous montrer quelque chose, J'aimerais savoir, Est-ce que je pourrais revenir jeudi ? It is the future stem plus the imparfait endings (pourr- + -ais). Est-ce que je peux revenir ? is correct too, just more direct.

See the table: Grammar tables, Conditional: would, could, polite requests.

Episode 17 · Le secret de Lucienne (Lucienne's secret)



On Tuesday evening Mme Berthier calls Théo up to her flat on the fifth floor. He tells her that Jacques is alive and that he waited for Simone all evening in 1962. At eighty-eight, she finally breaks a promise she has kept for sixty-four years.

Mme Berthier Alors, mon petit Théo ? Maya l'a vu, ce monsieur ?
Well, Théo dear? Did Maya see him, this gentleman?

Théo Oui, madame. Il s'appelle Jacques Vial. Il a attendu Simone jusqu'au dernier moment.
Yes, madame. His name is Jacques Vial. He waited for Simone until the very last moment.

Mme Berthier Jacques est vivant… J'ai promis à Simone. Je n'ai jamais rien dit.
Jacques is alive… I made Simone a promise. I've never said a word.

Théo Vous savez pourquoi Simone n'est pas venue, madame ?
Do you know why Simone didn't come, madame?

Mme Berthier Ce samedi-là, son père est tombé à l'atelier. Elle a passé la nuit à l'hôpital.
That Saturday, her father collapsed in the workshop. She spent the night at the hospital.

Théo Et la lettre de Jacques ? Elle n'a jamais répondu ?
And Jacques's letter? She never answered?

Mme Berthier Si. Elle a écrit sa réponse, et moi, Lucienne, j'ai monté la Grande-Côte en courant.
She did. She wrote her answer, and I, Lucienne, ran all the way up the Grande-Côte. (si: 'yes' after a negative question)

Théo Et vous êtes arrivée à temps ?
And did you get there in time?

Mme Berthier Non. À vingt et une heures, la mère Jeanne fermait. Elle m'a dit : « Il est parti. »
No. At nine p.m. old Jeanne was closing up. She told me: 'He's gone.'

Théo Mais après, pourquoi personne ne lui a écrit à Montréal ?
But afterwards, why did nobody write to him in Montréal?

Mme Berthier Elle n'avait pas son adresse, et elle était fière. « S'il m'aime, il écrira », elle disait.
She didn't have his address, and she was proud. 'If he loves me, he'll write,' she used to say.

Théo Ce n'est pas votre faute, madame. Vous avez couru aussi vite que possible.
It isn't your fault, madame. You ran as fast as you could.

Mme Berthier Si j'étais arrivée plus tôt, il aurait lu la lettre… Dites à Maya d'ouvrir l'enveloppe. Avec lui.
If I had got there earlier, he would have read the letter… Tell Maya to open the envelope. With him.

Théo Je le lui dirai ce soir, madame. Jeudi, ils la liront ensemble.
I'll tell her tonight, madame. On Thursday they'll read it together.

Words from this episode

- **Alors** *(ah-lor)* — So? / Well? (alors at the start of a question)
- **J'ai promis à Simone** *(zhay proh-mee ah see-mun)* — I promised Simone (promettre à quelqu'un)
- **Je n'ai jamais rien dit** *(zhuh nay zhah-meh ryaN dee)* — I've never said anything (ne… jamais rien wraps around ai)
- **son père est tombé** *(sohN pair eh tohN-bay)* — her father fell / collapsed (tomber takes être)
- **Elle n'a jamais répondu ?** *(el nah zhah-meh ray-pohN-dew)* — She never answered? (répondre)
- **en courant** *(ahN koo-rahN)* — running (courir: en + -ant)
- **Vous êtes arrivée à temps ?** *(voo‿zet ah-ree-vay ah tahN)* — Did you get there in time? (arrivée: Théo is asking a woman)
- **personne ne lui a écrit** *(pair-sun nuh lwee ah ay-kree)* — nobody wrote to him (personne as the subject comes first)
- **Si j'étais arrivée plus tôt, il aurait lu la lettre** *(see zhay-teh ah-ree-vay plew toh, eel oh-reh lew lah let-ruh)* — If I had got there earlier, he would have read the letter (B1 preview: si + plus-que-parfait, then the past conditional)
- **d'ouvrir l'enveloppe** *(doo-vreer lahN-vlop)* — to open the envelope (ouvrir)

Notice: Ne… jamais, ne… rien in the passé composé

In the passé composé the two parts of the negative wrap around the helper verb: Je n'ai jamais rien dit, Elle n'a jamais répondu ? Personne is different: as an object it goes after the past participle (Je ne l'ai dit à personne), and as the subject it comes first: Personne ne lui a écrit.

See the table: Grammar tables, Where the negative goes.

Episode 18 · La lettre jamais envoyée (The unsent letter)



On Thursday afternoon Maya comes back to the linden garden of Les Tilleuls with Simone's sealed envelope, marked 'Pour J.' Jacques is waiting on the same bench. She tells him about the night of 15 September 1962, then opens the letter she has never opened.

Jacques Bonjour, Maya. Je peux vous appeler Maya, n'est-ce pas ?
Hello, Maya. I can call you Maya, can't I?

Maya Bien sûr. Monsieur Vial, je sais maintenant pourquoi Simone n'est pas venue.
Of course. Monsieur Vial, I know now why Simone didn't come.

Jacques Je vous écoute. J'attends cette réponse depuis soixante-quatre ans.
I'm listening. I've been waiting sixty-four years for that answer.

Maya Ce samedi-là, son père est tombé à l'atelier. Elle a passé la nuit à l'Hôtel-Dieu.
That Saturday her father collapsed in the workshop. She spent the night at the Hôtel-Dieu hospital.

Jacques À l'hôpital… Et moi, je l'attendais au café où je l'avais vue la première fois.
At the hospital… And there I was, waiting for her at the café where I'd first seen her.

Maya Voici la lettre qu'elle a écrite cette nuit-là. Lucienne est arrivée trop tard.
Here is the letter she wrote that night. Lucienne got there too late.

Jacques Mes yeux sont fatigués. Vous voudriez bien me la lire ?
My eyes are tired. Would you be kind enough to read it to me?

Maya Je l'ouvre. « Je t'écris de l'hôpital. »
I'm opening it. 'I'm writing to you from the hospital.'

Jacques Continuez, Maya, je vous en prie.
Go on, Maya, please.

Maya « Ma réponse est oui. Oui à Montréal, oui à toi. »
'My answer is yes. Yes to Montréal, yes to you.'

Jacques Elle a dit oui… C'est la réponse que j'attendais.
She said yes… That's the answer I was waiting for.

Maya « Je t'aime. Simone. » Elle ne vous a jamais oublié, monsieur Vial.
'I love you. Simone.' She never forgot you, Monsieur Vial.

Jacques J'aimerais revoir la Croix-Rousse. Une dernière fois… ou une première fois.
I'd like to see the Croix-Rousse again. One last time… or one first time.

Maya Alors nous irons ensemble.
Then we'll go together.

Words from this episode

- **Je vous écoute** *(zhuh voo‿zay-koot)* — I'm listening (to you) (écouter)
- **depuis soixante-quatre ans** *(duh-pwee swah-sahNt-kah-trahN)* — for sixty-four years (and still now: depuis + present; no z, quatre ends in a sounded r)
- **au café où je l'avais vue** *(oh kah-fay oo zhuh lah-veh vew)* — at the café where I had seen her (où for a place)
- **la lettre qu'elle a écrite** *(lah let-ruh kel ah ay-kreet)* — the letter she wrote (écrite agrees with la lettre)
- **Vous voudriez bien me la lire ?** *(voo voo-dree-yay byaN muh lah leer)* — Would you kindly read it to me? (vouloir in the conditional: very polite)
- **Je l'ouvre** *(zhuh loovr)* — I'm opening it (ouvrir)
- **je vous en prie** *(zhuh voo‿zahN pree)* — please (formal)
- **la réponse que j'attendais** *(lah ray-pohNs kuh zhah-tahN-deh)* — the answer I was waiting for (attendre, imparfait)
- **Je t'aime** *(zhuh tem)* — I love you (aimer)
- **revoir la Croix-Rousse** *(ruh-vwahr lah krwah-roos)* — to see the Croix-Rousse again (re- + voir)

Notice: Qui, que, où: one sentence instead of two

Relative pronouns join two ideas. Que stands for the object: la réponse que j'attendais, la lettre qu'elle a écrite (écrite agrees with la lettre, because que comes before the verb). Où stands for a place: le café où je l'avais vue. Qui stands for the subject: c'est Lucienne qui a couru.

See the table: Grammar tables, Relative pronouns: qui, que, où, dont.

Episode 19 · On prépare un dîner (Planning a dinner)



On Friday Odile Vial, Jacques's daughter, comes into La Page Tournée to see Théo. Her father wants to come to the Croix-Rousse, but she is worried about his heart, the steep hill and the stairs. Théo, among his piles of books, has a plan.

Odile Bonjour, monsieur Garnier. C'est encore moi. Vous avez un moment ?
Hello, Monsieur Garnier. It's me again. Do you have a moment?

Théo Bien sûr, madame. Asseyez-vous… enfin, poussez les livres.
Of course, madame. Do sit down… well, push the books aside.

Odile Mon père veut venir à la Croix-Rousse samedi. Je suis inquiète : son cœur, la colline…
My father wants to come to the Croix-Rousse on Saturday. I'm worried: his heart, the hill…

Théo Je comprends. À mon avis, ce serait mieux sans escaliers.
I understand. In my opinion, it would be better with no stairs.

Odile Oui, chez Maya, il y a quatre étages sans ascenseur. C'est trop difficile pour lui.
Yes, at Maya's there are four floors and no lift. (US: elevator) It's too hard for him.

Théo On pourrait prendre un taxi jusqu'à la porte du restaurant.
We could take a taxi right to the door of the restaurant.

Odile Quel restaurant ? Il ne peut pas monter les escaliers, vous savez.
Which restaurant? He can't climb stairs, you know.

Théo Les Deux Collines, un bon bouchon sur la place. La salle est au rez-de-chaussée.
Les Deux Collines, a good bouchon on the square. The dining room is on the ground floor. (US: first floor)

Odile Un bouchon ? Je pense que ce serait parfait. Mais pas trop long, le dîner.
A bouchon? I think that would be perfect. But not too long a dinner.

Théo Une petite table près de la fenêtre, un dîner simple. Ce n'est pas la mer à boire.
A little table by the window, a simple dinner. It's not that hard. (literally: it's not drinking the sea)

Odile D'accord. Vous savez, mon père n'a pas souri comme ça depuis des années.
All right. You know, my father hasn't smiled like this for years.

Théo Alors préparons-lui une belle soirée. Il a un souhait ?
Then let's give him a lovely evening. Is there anything he'd wish for?

Odile Il voudrait une seule chose : revoir Lucienne.
He'd like just one thing: to see Lucienne again.

Théo Lucienne ? Ça marche. Je monte la voir ce soir.
Lucienne? Done. I'll go up and see her tonight.

Words from this episode

- **je suis inquiète** *(zhuh swee aN-kyet)* — I'm worried (inquiet, inquiète: Odile is a woman)
- **ce serait mieux** *(suh suh-reh myuh)* — it would be better (être in the conditional)
- **On pourrait prendre un taxi** *(ohN poo-reh prahNdr uhN tahk-see)* — We could take a taxi (pouvoir in the conditional: a suggestion)
- **monter les escaliers** *(mohN-tay lay‿zes-kah-lyay)* — to climb the stairs (monter)
- **un bon bouchon** *(uhN bohN boo-shohN)* — a good bouchon (a traditional Lyon restaurant; bon goes before the noun)
- **sur la place** *(sewr lah plahs)* — on the square
- **Je pense que** *(zhuh pahNs kuh)* — I think (that)
- **Ce n'est pas la mer à boire** *(suh neh pah lah mair ah bwahr)* — It's not that hard
- **préparons-lui une belle soirée** *(pray-pah-rohN-lwee ewn bel swah-ray)* — let's put on a lovely evening for him (préparer)
- **Ça marche** *(sah marsh)* — Done / That works

Notice: Beauty, age, goodness, size: adjectives before the noun

Most French adjectives go after the noun: un dîner simple. A small group goes before it, the BAGS adjectives (beauty, age, goodness, size). Théo plans un bon bouchon, une petite table and une belle soirée. Belle is the feminine of beau.

See the table: Grammar tables, Adjectives that go before the noun: BAGS.

Episode 20 · Un nouveau départ (A new beginning)



On Saturday night Maya and Théo stand outside Les Deux Collines, on the place de la Croix-Rousse. Through the window Jacques and Lucienne are talking like old friends. Maya is holding a small wooden box that Jacques has just given her.

Théo Regarde-les, à la fenêtre. Ils rient comme deux vieux amis.
Look at them, at the window. They're laughing like two old friends.

Maya Soixante-quatre ans après… J'espère qu'ils vont se revoir souvent.
Sixty-four years later… I hope they'll see each other often.

Théo Et cette petite boîte, qu'est-ce que c'est ?
And this little box, what is it?

Maya Jacques me l'a offerte. Des lettres en plomb, de l'imprimerie Delorme.
Jacques gave it to me. Lead letters, from the Delorme printing works.

Théo Elles disent S et J… Simone et Jacques.
They spell S and J… Simone and Jacques.

Maya Il les a composées en soixante-deux, pour une carte qu'il n'a jamais imprimée.
He set them in '62, for a card he never printed.

Théo Alors il faut finir son travail. Tu as une idée, toi, la graphiste ?
Then someone has to finish his work. Any ideas, Ms Graphic Designer?

Maya Oui. J'aimerais faire un petit livre avec les lettres. Et toi, tu le vendrais ?
Yes. I'd like to make a little book of the letters. And would you sell it?

Théo Bien sûr, à La Page Tournée ! C'est génial. Mais il faudra rester à Lyon…
Of course, at La Page Tournée! That's brilliant. But you'd have to stay in Lyon…

Maya Je reste. J'ai décidé. Ici, entre la colline qui travaille et la colline qui prie.
I'm staying. I've decided. Here, between the hill that works and the hill that prays.

Théo J'en suis très heureux, Maya. Vraiment.
I'm really glad, Maya. Truly.

Maya C'est leur histoire… et maintenant, on écrit la nôtre.
It's their story… and now we're writing ours.

Théo Demain, dix heures, en haut de la montée de la Grande-Côte ?
Tomorrow, ten o'clock, at the top of the montée de la Grande-Côte?

Maya J'y serai.
I'll be there.

Words from this episode

- **J'espère qu'ils vont se revoir souvent** *(zhes-pair keel vohN suh ruh-vwahr soo-vahN)* — I hope they'll see each other often (espérer que + indicative)
- **Jacques me l'a offerte** *(zhahk muh lah oh-fairt)* — Jacques gave it to me (offrir; offerte agrees with la boîte)
- **J'aimerais faire un petit livre** *(zhem-reh fair uhN puh-tee lee-vruh)* — I'd like to make a little book (a hope: conditional)
- **tu le vendrais** *(tew luh vahN-dreh)* — you'd sell it (vendre in the conditional)
- **C'est génial** *(seh zhay-nyahl)* — That's brilliant
- **Je reste** *(zhuh rest)* — I'm staying (rester)
- **on écrit** *(ohN‿nay-kree)* — we're writing (on = nous in speech; écrire)
- **la nôtre** *(lah nohtr)* — ours (la nôtre = notre histoire)
- **dix heures** *(dee‿zuhr)* — ten o'clock (z liaison: dix ends in x)
- **J'y serai** *(zhee suh-ray)* — I'll be there (être in the futur simple)

Notice: La nôtre, la leur: possessive pronouns

Maya says C'est leur histoire… et maintenant, on écrit la nôtre. La nôtre means 'ours' and stands for notre histoire, so it takes the article and gender of histoire: la. 'Theirs' works the same way: cette histoire, c'est la leur.

See the table: Grammar tables, Possessive pronouns: mine, yours...

Questions

Episode 1 · L'emménagement

1. Why does Maya ask Théo for help?
   a. Her car has broken down
   b. She can't find the street
   c. She has lost her keys
   d. The building has no lift (US: elevator)
2. Whose flat is Maya moving into?
   a. A friend's from London
   b. Her grandmother's
   c. Her mother's
   d. Théo's
3. What does Théo remember about Simone?
   a. She bought a novel every Saturday
   b. She drank a coffee with him every morning
   c. She sold him her old books
   d. She walked to the river every Sunday
4. What does Théo find behind the blue tile?
   a. Un livre bleu
   b. Une petite boîte en fer
   c. Une photo de Simone
   d. Une vieille clé

Episode 2 · Les lettres de J.

1. What does Maya find in the tin box?
   a. A diary and some old keys
   b. Three letters signed J. and a sealed envelope
   c. Three postcards from Montréal
   d. Two letters and an old photo
2. Why won't Maya open the envelope?
   a. It isn't hers
   b. It's empty
   c. She's afraid of what it says
   d. Théo tells her not to
3. How do Maya and Théo know that J. is a man?
   a. He signs with his full name
   b. He writes prêt, not prête
   c. Lucienne says so in the letter
   d. The envelope says Monsieur
4. Where does J. ask Simone to meet him on Saturday?
   a. Au Café des Canuts
   b. En haut de la Grande-Côte
   c. À Fourvière
   d. À la gare de Perrache

Episode 3 · Une adresse disparue

1. What is a traboule, according to Théo?
   a. A kind of silk scarf
   b. A little street market
   c. A passage through the buildings
   d. An old café on the square
2. Why are the ceilings in Maya's flat so high?
   a. The building used to be a church
   b. They were built for the silk looms
   c. To keep the rooms cool in summer
   d. To make room for big bookshelves
3. What do Maya and Théo find at the café's old address?
   a. A bakery
   b. A bookshop
   c. An empty shop
   d. An optician's
4. What is Théo's plan at the end?
   a. On va demander à M. Rossi.
   b. On va monter à Fourvière.
   c. On va ouvrir l'enveloppe.
   d. On va prendre une traboule.

Episode 4 · Le voisin de la cour

1. When did the Café des Canuts close?
   a. In 1962, the year of the letters
   b. In 1985, about forty years ago
   c. In 2001, about twenty-five years ago
   d. Last year
2. Who were the café's regulars, according to M. Rossi?
   a. Bus drivers and market sellers
   b. Silk weavers and typesetters from a printing works
   c. Students and their teachers
   d. Tourists and artists
3. Why is the name Delorme important to Maya?
   a. It's her grandmother's maiden name
   b. It's the name of Théo's bookshop
   c. It's written on the sealed envelope
   d. J. mentions a Monsieur Delorme in a letter
4. Who does M. Rossi tell Maya to ask?
   a. L'opticien, sur la place
   b. M. Delorme, à l'imprimerie
   c. Mme Berthier, au cinquième
   d. Théo, à la librairie

Episode 5 · Une porte qui se ferme

1. Why does Théo go up to Mme Berthier's flat?
   a. To bring her a detective novel
   b. To fix her loose kitchen tile
   c. To give her a letter from Maya
   d. To invite her to the bookshop
2. What does Mme Berthier remember about Simone?
   a. Her bicycle and her dog
   b. Her blue scarf and her laugh
   c. Her long letters
   d. Her red coat and her songs
3. Who does Mme Berthier remember from 1962?
   a. A loud student from Paris
   b. A sailor from Le Havre
   c. A silk weaver from the hill
   d. A tall, shy boy from the printing works
4. How does Mme Berthier end the conversation?
   a. Bonne nuit, mon petit Théo.
   b. Bonsoir, monsieur Garnier.
   c. Oui, je m'appelle Lucienne.
   d. Revenez demain, Théo.

Episode 6 · Aux archives

1. When did the Delorme printing works close?
   a. In 1957
   b. In 1962
   c. In 1975
   d. In 1985
2. What does M. Faure find for Maya?
   a. A 1962 issue of Le Progrès on microfilm
   b. A letter signed J.
   c. A list of the café's regulars
   d. A photo of the Café des Canuts
3. According to M. Faure, what happened to the typesetters after the works closed?
   a. Some left, others stayed in Lyon
   b. They all left for Paris
   c. They all stayed at the works
   d. They opened a café together
4. How does Maya say who she is looking for?
   a. Je cherche un café. Son nom commence par C.
   b. Je cherche un homme. Son nom commence par D.
   c. Je cherche un homme. Son prénom commence par J.
   d. Je cherche une femme. Son prénom commence par S.

Episode 7 · La photo

1. What is written on the back of the photo?
   a. Café des Canuts, June 1962. S.
   b. For Simone, quai Saint-Vincent, 1962. J.
   c. You and me, Fourvière, May 1962. J.
   d. You and me, quai Saint-Antoine, June 1962. J.
2. Why does Théo suggest they say tu?
   a. Maya asked him to
   b. Simone always said tu to him
   c. They're reading her grandmother's love letters together
   d. They're the same age
3. What does Théo read on the sign behind the couple?
   a. BRUN, primeurs (a greengrocer's stall)
   b. Café des Canuts
   c. DELORME, imprimerie (a printing works)
   d. La Page Tournée (a bookshop)
4. How does Maya agree to say tu?
   a. Non. Vous avez tort.
   b. Oui. On se voit quand ?
   c. Oui. Tu as raison.
   d. Oui. Vous avez raison.

Episode 8 · Le marchand se souvient

1. What does Maya buy at the stall?
   a. A kilo of figs
   b. Half a kilo of figs
   c. Half a kilo of peaches
   d. Two kilos of apples
2. How old was M. Brun when the photo was taken?
   a. Sixteen
   b. Sixty-four
   c. Thirty
   d. Twenty
3. How does M. Brun remember Simone?
   a. As a customer who lived by the Saône
   b. As a girl from the printing works
   c. As the daughter of the café owner
   d. As the silk weaver's daughter from rue Dumenge
4. Where does M. Brun say Jacques lives?
   a. Il habite au Canada, je crois.
   b. Il habite montée Saint-Sébastien, je crois.
   c. Il habite quai Saint-Vincent, je crois.
   d. Il habite rue Dumenge, je crois.

Episode 9 · Le mauvais Jacques

1. Why does M. Perrin ask Maya to repeat?
   a. He doesn't hear very well
   b. He doesn't know Simone
   c. He doesn't understand her accent
   d. He is on the phone
2. Is M. Perrin the young man in the photo?
   a. He isn't sure, the photo is too old
   b. No, he laughs and says he was never that handsome
   c. Yes, but he doesn't want to say so
   d. Yes, he recognises himself at once
3. How does M. Perrin describe the other Jacques?
   a. Handsome and proud
   b. Short and talkative
   c. Tall and funny
   d. Tall and shy
4. How does Maya say which Jacques she means?
   a. Celle de la photo.
   b. Celui de la photo.
   c. Ceux de la photo.
   d. Lequel de la photo ?

Episode 10 · Un après-midi de pluie

1. Why does Maya want to stop looking for J.?
   a. Canada is huge, he may be dead and her life is in London
   b. Her mother wants the flat sold quickly
   c. She has already found him
   d. Théo asked her to stop
2. What does Théo tell Maya about his father?
   a. He died thirteen years ago
   b. He died three years ago
   c. He left for Canada
   d. He ran the bookshop before Théo
3. What helped Théo after his loss?
   a. A trip to Canada
   b. Books and the people in the neighbourhood
   c. Moving to London
   d. Working at the market
4. Where was the second letter posted, according to Théo?
   a. Fleurie, dans le Beaujolais.
   b. Lyon, à la Croix-Rousse.
   c. Montréal, au Canada.
   d. Paris, près de la gare.

Episode 11 · Dans les vignes du Beaujolais

1. What surname does M. Dumas give Maya for Jacques?
    a. Cordier
    b. Dumas
    c. Perrin
    d. Vial
2. When did M. Dumas's father buy the Vial family's vines?
    a. In 1962
    b. In 1975
    c. In 1985
    d. In 2001
3. Why isn't Jacques at the revole this year?
    a. He fell out with the Dumas family
    b. He is helping with another harvest
    c. He still lives in Montréal
    d. His daughter said no because of his heart
4. How does M. Dumas say Jacques left in 1962?
    a. Il est parti en soixante-deux.
    b. Il est resté en soixante-deux.
    c. Il est revenu en soixante-deux.
    d. Il partait en soixante-deux.

Episode 12 · Un coup de téléphone

1. Why can't Théo speak to M. Vial directly?
    a. Calls and visits go through his daughter
    b. M. Vial doesn't live there any more
    c. M. Vial is in hospital
    d. Visits are only on Sundays
2. Until when is Odile away?
    a. Until Monday
    b. Until next month
    c. Until Saturday
    d. Until Thursday
3. Which phone number does Théo leave?
    a. Maya's mobile number
    b. Mme Berthier's number
    c. Odile's home number
    d. The bookshop's number
4. How does Théo ask to leave a message for Odile?
    a. Est-ce que je peux le laisser ici ?
    b. Est-ce que je peux leur laisser un message ?
    c. Est-ce que je peux lui dire un mot ?
    d. Est-ce que je peux lui laisser un message ?

Episode 13 · Le message

1. Who is the message from?
   a. Jacques Vial himself
   b. M. Dumas, the winegrower
   c. Odile Vial, Jacques's daughter
   d. Sabine, the day receptionist
2. Why doesn't Odile want a visit this week?
   a. Her father is in hospital
   b. Her father is too tired
   c. She is away until next month
   d. The residence is closed to visitors
3. What does Maya realise at the end?
   a. Odile wants to meet her on Saturday
   b. Sabine forgot to pass on the message
   c. Théo has already met Jacques
   d. Théo has known about Jacques for three days
4. How does Yanis ask Maya if she knows M. Garnier?
   a. Vous la connaissez ?
   b. Vous le connaissez ?
   c. Vous le savez ?
   d. Vous les connaissez ?

Episode 14 · Pardon, sur le quai

1. Why did Théo keep the phone call secret?
   a. He forgot to tell her
   b. He wanted to meet Jacques on his own first
   c. He was afraid another door would close on Maya
   d. Odile asked him to say nothing
2. What does Théo promise Maya?
   a. No more secrets
   b. To close the bookshop on Saturday
   c. To open the envelope with her
   d. To phone Odile tomorrow
3. Why hasn't Maya opened the envelope?
   a. Her mother wants to read it first
   b. It isn't hers: it's for J.
   c. She is afraid of what it says
   d. Théo told her not to
4. How does Maya tell Théo he kept it from her?
   a. Tu ne l'as pas lu.
   b. Tu ne le lui as pas dit.
   c. Tu ne me l'as pas dit.
   d. Tu ne me l'as pas donné.

Episode 15 · Au Gros Caillou

1. When will Maya meet Jacques?
   a. On Monday at 3 p.m.
   b. On Monday at 9 p.m.
   c. On Saturday at 6 p.m.
   d. On Thursday at 3 p.m.
2. Why did Odile agree to the visit?
   a. Her father is feeling much better
   b. Her father keeps a photo of a young woman in his wallet
   c. Jacques asked to meet Maya
   d. Théo promised the visit would be short
3. What does Maya say about the hill?
   a. For the first time, she feels at home there
   b. She finds it too steep
   c. She has always felt at home there
   d. She wants to go back to London
4. How does Maya say she is nervous?
   a. Je suis curieuse.
   b. Je suis heureuse.
   c. Je suis nerveuse.
   d. Je suis nerveux.

Episode 16 · La rencontre

1. How is Maya related to Simone?
   a. She's her daughter
   b. She's her granddaughter
   c. She's her neighbour
   d. She's her niece
2. What is written on the back of Jacques's photo?
   a. For Jacques. Don't forget me. S.
   b. For Simone. Wait for me. J.
   c. Lyon, June 1962. With love.
   d. You and me, quai Saint-Antoine, June 1962. J.
3. Why did Jacques never write to Simone?
   a. He had lost her address
   b. He thought she would write if she loved him
   c. He was already married in Montréal
   d. His boss told him not to
4. How does Maya ask if she can come back?
   a. Est-ce que je devrais partir jeudi ?
   b. Est-ce que je pourrais revenir jeudi ?
   c. Est-ce que je pourrais revenir lundi ?
   d. Est-ce que vous pourriez venir jeudi ?

Episode 17 · Le secret de Lucienne

1. Why didn't Simone go to meet Jacques?
   a. Her father collapsed and she stayed at the hospital
   b. Lucienne forgot to tell her the time
   c. She didn't love him any more
   d. She was working late at the looms
2. When did Lucienne reach the café?
   a. At 4 p.m.
   b. At 6 p.m.
   c. At 8.30 p.m.
   d. At 9 p.m.
3. Why did Simone never write to Jacques in Montréal?
   a. Her father would not let her
   b. Her letters came back unopened
   c. Lucienne told her not to
   d. She had no address, and she was proud
4. What message does Mme Berthier send to Maya?
   a. Dites à Maya d'ouvrir l'enveloppe. Avec lui.
   b. Dites à Maya de brûler l'enveloppe. Ce soir.
   c. Dites à Maya de garder l'enveloppe. Pour elle.
   d. Dites à Maya de lire l'enveloppe. Toute seule.

Episode 18 · La lettre jamais envoyée

1. Where did Simone spend the night of the meeting?
   a. At Perrache station
   b. At the Café des Canuts
   c. At the Hôtel-Dieu hospital
   d. In her father's workshop
2. Why does Jacques ask Maya to read the letter?
   a. He has forgotten his glasses at home
   b. He is afraid to open it
   c. His eyes are tired
   d. Odile asked her to read it
3. What was Simone's answer?
   a. No, because of her father
   b. She would never leave Lyon
   c. Wait until next year
   d. Yes, to Montréal and to him
4. What would Jacques like to do?
   a. J'aimerais revoir Fleurie.
   b. J'aimerais revoir Fourvière.
   c. J'aimerais revoir la Croix-Rousse.
   d. J'aimerais revoir Montréal.

Episode 19 · On prépare un dîner

1. What worries Odile?
   a. Her father's eyesight
   b. Her father's heart and the steep hill
   c. The cost of the dinner
   d. The rain on Saturday
2. Why does Théo choose Les Deux Collines?
   a. It's in the old Café des Canuts
   b. It's next to the hospital
   c. Its dining room is on the ground floor
   d. Odile's father knows the owner
3. What does Odile say about her father?
   a. He doesn't want to go out
   b. He has never eaten in a bouchon
   c. He hasn't smiled like this for years
   d. He wants to go back to Montréal
4. What is the one thing Jacques would like?
   a. Il voudrait une seule chose : revoir Fleurie.
   b. Il voudrait une seule chose : revoir le café.
   c. Il voudrait une seule chose : revoir Lucienne.
   d. Il voudrait une seule chose : revoir Montréal.

Episode 20 · Un nouveau départ

1. What is Jacques's gift to Maya?
   a. A bottle of Fleurie wine
   b. A copy of Le Petit Prince
   c. A little box of old lead letters
   d. The original 1962 photo
2. What would Maya like to make?
   a. A film about Simone
   b. A little book of the letters
   c. A website for the bookshop
   d. An exhibition at the library
3. What has Maya decided?
   a. To go back to London
   b. To move to Montréal
   c. To sell the flat
   d. To stay in Lyon
4. Where does Théo suggest meeting tomorrow?
   a. Au Café des Canuts.
   b. Au Gros Caillou.
   c. En haut de la montée de la Grande-Côte.
   d. Sur le quai Saint-Antoine.

Answer key

1.1 d) The building has no lift (US: elevator)
1.2 b) Her grandmother's
1.3 a) She bought a novel every Saturday
1.4 b) Une petite boîte en fer
2.1 b) Three letters signed J. and a sealed envelope
2.2 a) It isn't hers
2.3 b) He writes prêt, not prête
2.4 a) Au Café des Canuts
3.1 c) A passage through the buildings
3.2 b) They were built for the silk looms
3.3 d) An optician's
3.4 a) On va demander à M. Rossi.
4.1 b) In 1985, about forty years ago
4.2 b) Silk weavers and typesetters from a printing works
4.3 d) J. mentions a Monsieur Delorme in a letter
4.4 c) Mme Berthier, au cinquième
5.1 a) To bring her a detective novel
5.2 b) Her blue scarf and her laugh
5.3 d) A tall, shy boy from the printing works
5.4 b) Bonsoir, monsieur Garnier.
6.1 c) In 1975
6.2 a) A 1962 issue of Le Progrès on microfilm
6.3 a) Some left, others stayed in Lyon
6.4 c) Je cherche un homme. Son prénom commence par J.
7.1 d) You and me, quai Saint-Antoine, June 1962. J.
7.2 c) They're reading her grandmother's love letters together
7.3 a) BRUN, primeurs (a greengrocer's stall)
7.4 c) Oui. Tu as raison.
8.1 b) Half a kilo of figs
8.2 d) Twenty
8.3 d) As the silk weaver's daughter from rue Dumenge
8.4 b) Il habite montée Saint-Sébastien, je crois.
9.1 a) He doesn't hear very well
9.2 b) No, he laughs and says he was never that handsome
9.3 d) Tall and shy
9.4 b) Celui de la photo.
10.1 a) Canada is huge, he may be dead and her life is in London
10.2 b) He died three years ago
10.3 b) Books and the people in the neighbourhood
10.4 a) Fleurie, dans le Beaujolais.
11.1 d) Vial
11.2 c) In 1985
11.3 d) His daughter said no because of his heart
11.4 a) Il est parti en soixante-deux.
12.1 a) Calls and visits go through his daughter
12.2 d) Until Thursday
12.3 d) The bookshop's number
12.4 d) Est-ce que je peux lui laisser un message ?
13.1 c) Odile Vial, Jacques's daughter
13.2 b) Her father is too tired
13.3 d) Théo has known about Jacques for three days
13.4 b) Vous le connaissez ?
14.1 c) He was afraid another door would close on Maya
14.2 a) No more secrets
14.3 b) It isn't hers: it's for J.
14.4 c) Tu ne me l'as pas dit.
15.1 a) On Monday at 3 p.m.
15.2 b) Her father keeps a photo of a young woman in his wallet
15.3 a) For the first time, she feels at home there
15.4 c) Je suis nerveuse.
16.1 b) She's her granddaughter
16.2 a) For Jacques. Don't forget me. S.
16.3 b) He thought she would write if she loved him
16.4 b) Est-ce que je pourrais revenir jeudi ?
17.1 a) Her father collapsed and she stayed at the hospital
17.2 d) At 9 p.m.
17.3 d) She had no address, and she was proud
17.4 a) Dites à Maya d'ouvrir l'enveloppe. Avec lui.
18.1 c) At the Hôtel-Dieu hospital
18.2 c) His eyes are tired
18.3 d) Yes, to Montréal and to him
18.4 c) J'aimerais revoir la Croix-Rousse.
19.1 b) Her father's heart and the steep hill
19.2 c) Its dining room is on the ground floor
19.3 c) He hasn't smiled like this for years
19.4 c) Il voudrait une seule chose : revoir Lucienne.
20.1 c) A little box of old lead letters
20.2 b) A little book of the letters
20.3 d) To stay in Lyon
20.4 c) En haut de la montée de la Grande-Côte.

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